Tooltips & Popovers

In short

Extra information that pops up, like a tooltip, often only works with a mouse. Make it show on keyboard focus too, and make sure screen readers announce it. Let people close it with the Escape key.

What is it for?

Tooltips and popovers give users extra information when they need it (like for an icon button). But they often fail accessibility by being:

- Mouse-only. They don't appear for keyboard users (focus).
- Silent. Screen readers don't announce the new content.
- Hard to close. Users get 'stuck', or the tooltip vanishes too fast.

It's important to note that popovers and modals are not the same thing. A modal demands your full attention, while a popover just offers extra information.

How to support it

They must work for keyboard, mouse, and screen reader users.

- For simple tooltips (read-only information):
    - Show on hover and focus
    - Keep it visible while the pointer is over it, and let users close it with the Escape key
    - Use aria-describedby to link the trigger button to the tooltip. This is how screen readers announce it
- For complex popovers (with buttons or links inside):
    - Trigger on click (not hover). This is more robust
    - Manage keyboard focus: Move focus into the popover when it opens, and return it to the trigger button when it closes. Don't trap focus inside, as that's only for modals

    - Make it easy to close: Support the Escape key and include a visible close button

Useful links

- Accessible Rich Internet Applications (ARIA) Authoring Practices - Tooltip Pattern

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

ARIA: Accessible Rich Internet Applications